

Using clauses correctly

CLAUSES MUST BE PUT IN A CERTAIN ORDER FOR A SENTENCE CONTAINING SEVERAL CLAUSES TO MAKE SENSE.

A main clause must make complete sense on its own, while a subordinate clause only makes sense when it is connected to a main clause. When clauses are put in the wrong place in a sentence, the meaning of that sentence changes.

SEE ALSO

- ◀ 64–65 Phrases
- ◀ 66–67 Clauses
- ◀ 68–69 Sentences
- ◀ 70–71 Compound sentences
- ◀ 72–73 Complex sentences

Breaking sentences down

Certain rules must be followed for a complex sentence to make sense. If a sentence is broken down into its component parts, it has to be clear which clause refers to which subject. Each clause must have its own subject and verb, and a main clause must express a complete thought.

This is a main clause because it makes sense on its own.

This subordinate clause explains why Lauren (the subject of the sentence) was upset.

Lauren was upset because she had lost her swimsuit, which was new.

This subordinate clause is placed at the end of the sentence because it describes the swimsuit, not Lauren.



Identifying a misplaced clause

If a clause describes someone or something, it needs to be placed as close as possible to the person or thing it describes. Sometimes a phrase or another clause gets in the way, and the whole meaning of a sentence changes as a result. When this happens, the sentence should be reworded so that the potentially confusing clause is placed next to the person or thing that it describes.

main clause

This adverbial phrase describes where the café is.

Lauren went to the café **next to the beach** that was playing music.



This subordinate clause implies that the beach was playing music, rather than the café.

Lauren went to the café **that was playing music.**



The adverbial phrase has been removed, so the subordinate clause is now describing the café.

Lauren went to the café that was playing music **next to the beach.**



The adverbial phrase has been put back into the sentence, and the sentence now makes sense.

GLOSSARY

Adverbial phrase A group of words such as “in July of last year” that perform the same role as an adverb and answer questions such as: How? When? Why? Where? How often?

Main clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own.

Subject The person or thing that is performing the action of the verb.

Subordinate clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb but depends on a main clause for its meaning.